

'The arts serve no practical purpose in our everyday lives.' Discuss in reference to your society.

Understanding the Question

The arts

- A broad term referring to various creative and imaginative endeavours that encompass visual arts, literary arts and the performing arts.
- Includes both the product and process of engaging with the arts

No practical purpose

- 'No' signals an absolute proposition
- The phrase suggests that the arts either do not produce any tangible outcomes, provide effective solutions or serve a real purpose in a given situation. In other words, they are pointless, useless, or frivolous.

Everyday lives

- Candidates must explain how the arts contribute positively to one's day-to-day living, including one's work or studies, general well-being, et cetera.
- Candidates should not discuss the significance of the arts to society in terms of changing the world for the better by highlighting socio-political issues and galvanising the public into action, or boosting a country's economic growth.

Your society

- Discuss the arts in relation to Singapore: i.e. how the local context affects the way we consume or produce the arts such that it brings about particular outcomes or the lack thereof.
- Characteristics of Singapore include its pragmatism, conservative values, aging population, highly urbanised environment, and stressful work culture.

Conclusion

While some might perceive the arts to be of little or no practical value to our everyday life, such a view fails to consider the important psychological and social benefits that come about from engaging with the arts. Moreover, recent changes in society have in fact raised the economic value of the arts.

Approach

- A. Discuss why the arts are perceived to serve no practical purpose in everyday life.
- B. Refute Part A and explain why such a view is overly dismissive of the arts.
- C. Discuss why the arts can serve other practical purposes in everyday life.

Suggested Outline

Part A: Discuss why the arts are perceived to serve no practical purpose in everyday life.

A1. Sceptics might argue that the arts are merely sources of entertainment that contribute little to one's livelihood.

- In a society that has a strong culture of pragmatism, the arts might be deemed as simply as sources of short-lived entertainment.
 - o *According to the 2015 Population Survey on the Arts, arts and culture were ranked among the lowest priorities relative to bread and butter issues such as job security.*
- Moreover, opportunities to pursue a business venture or career in the arts industry are seemingly limited within the local economy.
 - o *As reported by the Ministry for Manpower, the Singapore economy is primarily driven by its finance, healthcare, information technology, and legal industries.*
 - o Thus, the structure of Singapore's economy might lead one to think that the arts carry little economic viability.

Part B: Refute Part A by addressing why such a view is overly dismissive of the arts.

B1. Engaging in the arts even as a leisure pursuit can help to boost one's creativity – a 21st century competency that is highly valued in Singapore's knowledge-based economy.

- Through an exploration of the various elements of art – line, shape, colour, texture, form, and space – to create meaning, we are encouraged to be original and innovative.
- Similarly, consuming works of art in the form of literary texts encourages readers to be imaginative. As readers are immersed in alternative worlds that deviate from their everyday realities, they explore new possibilities and broaden their perspectives.
- Scientific research shows us that when humans are exposed to novel ideas through the arts, they create new synaptic connections. As these connections build on one another, it increases our neural activity and prompts us to be increasingly open to learning. This trait is highly associated with creative achievement, as reported in research-based publications such as Scientific American, and Brain and Cognition.

B2. Recent economic trends suggest that local creative industries are in fact likely to expand in the near future, thereby creating greater business and job opportunities in these industries.

- There have been continual efforts to grow Singapore's knowledge-based economy and to develop it into a global cultural hub.
- Building on The Renaissance City Plans, strategies from the recent Arts and Culture Strategic Review (ACSR) in 2012 continue to pave the way for further development of the arts and culture sector.
 - o *According to the National Arts Council, the ACSR brought in an injection of S\$270 million over 2012 to 2016.*
 - o The government has made efforts to attract highly established international companies to set up offices in Singapore.

- *Examples of key players in the digital animation industry include LucasFilms, Electronic Arts (EA) and Koei from Japan.*
 - *Apart from creating job opportunities, these companies also bring in the expertise necessary to facilitate the growth of local creative industries.*
- With the digital wave sweeping across industries, more companies are seeking employees trained in either the visual arts or design to boost their online presence among consumers.
 - *According to PricewaterhouseCooper's Global entertainment and media outlook 2016–2020 report, both Internet and mobile advertising are expected to be on the rise over the next five years.*
 - *In the recent 2018 Emerging Jobs in Singapore Report by LinkedIn, it was found that User Experience Designers were among the most highly sought after in the local labour market.*

B3. Moreover, we should not underestimate the value of the arts as mere sources of entertainment, given that engaging with the arts can in fact help us to relieve stress and improve our moods.

- *According to the 2015 Population Survey on the Arts, 73% of Singaporeans surveyed agreed that the arts and culture improve the quality of life for everyone.*
- As we face the challenge of having to cope with the pressures of living in a highly urbanised and competitive society, many turn to the arts as a way of unwinding after a taxing day. Fully engaging in art-related activities, such as painting, sculpting, and choreographing, can help to immerse us in a meditative-like state. This process helps to relieve us of mental fatigue as it distract us from daily struggles and issues, leaving us in a better state to cope with the demands of work. This also helps to improve our work productivity.
 - *Popular arts-based leisure activities in Singapore include Art Detox and Art Jamming.*
 - *The former consists of art-making activities aimed at relieving stress and anxiety among young adults aged 18 to 29.*
 - *The latter involves acrylic painting and can be easily found along Singapore's main shopping district – Orchard Road.*
 - *According to the 2015 Singapore Cultural Statistics report, membership in performing arts interest groups in community clubs and residents' committees have jumped by almost 50 per cent between 2013 and 2014 – from 24,767 to 36,766. This increase in enrolment rates suggests that there is a growing interest in the arts for leisure purposes among local residents.*
- Furthermore, the aesthetic element of the arts can have an uplifting effect on people.
 - *Especially in a concrete jungle like Singapore, putting up mural art pieces that have been tastefully done in public spaces can help to elevate one's mood during an otherwise depressing commute to work or school. In other words, works of art*

help to inject a much needed vibrancy into one's environment, especially in a highly urbanised nation-state like Singapore.

- *In recognition of this, public art schemes have been initiated by the authorities. This includes the Land Transport Authority's Art in Transit Programme and Urban Redevelopment Authority Public (URA) Sculpture Masterplan.*
 - *Examples which can be found along the Circle line include "Through the Looking Glass" by A Dose of Light & Yoma Studio at Lorong Chuan MRT station and "The Perfect Moment" by Roy Zhang at Stadium MRT station*

Part C: Discuss how the arts do in fact serve a practical purpose in our everyday lives.

C1. The arts play an important role in therapy for those suffering from neurological diseases.

- Given that dementia incidence is set to increase with the aging population in Singapore, there is growing interest in exploring how the arts can help at-risk seniors to recuperate.
- Day-care centres such as The Care Library and Montessori for Dementia Care employ the use of music therapy for its clients.
 - Depending on the conditions of the client, certified music therapists conduct research-based treatment programmes which include activities such as listening to a particular genre of music and collaborative music making. The sensory stimulation that arises from such activities evoke positive feelings of familiarity and predictability, which in turn help to stave the cognitive decline of clients.
- Likewise, art therapy has been used to help seniors who are at risk of dementia to recuperate.
 - In art therapy classes, therapists would prompt participants to reflect on themes such as familial relationships and help them to express their thoughts and feelings through art. This process helps to stimulate their minds as they are asked to recall their memories.
 - The seniors are also brought on trips led by docents to the National Gallery Singapore and National University of Singapore (NUS) museum to view paintings that relate to their memories and life experiences. This exposure in turn serves as a trigger for stimulating and meaningful discussions.

C2. Especially in a society where there is the rising incidence of social isolation, the arts can play a helpful role in facilitating social interaction and bonding among people.

- Engagement in the arts provide opportunities for non-threatening experiences that encourage people who share similar interests to interact with one another.
- For instance, the arts has served as a platform for people to widen their social circle and form communities.
 - *Since 2012, the National Arts Council (NAC) has organised an annual festival, Silver Arts, which presents collaborations between artists, arts organisations and community partners to integrate the arts into the lifestyles of seniors. Through a range of age appropriate activities, including performances and workshops,*

seniors can also showcase their creative talents by co-creating content. This further allows for the elderly to share their stories, thereby helping to forge stronger inter-generational understanding.

- *Other similar initiatives that encourage social bonding by the NAC include Arts in Your Neighbourhood and NAC-Exxonmobil Concert in the Park.*
- The social relationships that are forged and strengthened through such activities further encourage protective health behaviour and prevent feelings of loneliness that may contribute to suicidal tendencies.